Contents

Pembroke Mayoral Debates: Full Report and Rankings **1**
Overall Judgment . . . 2
Sources and Method . . . 2
Debate 1 — Tuesday, September 22, 2026 . . . 3
Rankings and Reasons . . . 3
Debate 1 — Complete Topic Summary . . . 4
Opening statements — approximately 00:04:05–00:08:35 . . . 4
1. Recreation and fiscal responsibility — 00:08:44–00:20:35 . . . 5
2. Homelessness, mental health, and addiction — 00:20:43–00:32:17 . . . 5
3. Public trust and transparency — 00:32:19–00:42:17 . . . 6
4. Public transit and Handi-Bus — 00:42:21–00:53:15 . . . 6
5. Diversity, inclusion, and advisory committees — 00:53:20–01:02:20 . . . 6
6. Business, downtown vacancies, and housing — 01:02:26–01:13:27 . . . 6
7. Shared services and possible amalgamation — 01:13:39–01:19:58 . . . 7
Closing statements — 01:20:26–01:24:53 . . . 7
Debate 2 — Monday, October 5, 2026 . . . 7
Rankings and Reasons . . . 7
Debate 2 — Complete Topic Summary . . . 8
Opening statements — 00:07:21–00:21:33 . . . 8
1. Three priorities — directed to LeMay, 00:21:58–00:29:39 . . . 9
2. Meaningful transparency — directed to Michaelis, 00:29:46–00:37:03 . . . 9
3. Waterfront revitalization — directed to Sambey, 00:37:27–00:43:53 . . . 9
4. Strong mayor powers — directed to Gervais, 00:44:02–00:50:05 . . . 9
5. Infrastructure versus visible projects — directed to Slaughter, 00:50:14–00:57:20 . . . 10
6. Affordable housing — directed to Abdallah, 00:57:31–01:03:50 . . . 10
7. Services, infrastructure, and property taxes — 01:04:33–01:10:29 . . . 10
8. Barriers to economic growth — 01:10:36–01:18:12 . . . 10
9. Downtown vacancies and safety — 01:18:25–01:28:46 . . . 10
10. Measurable results after four years — 01:29:00–01:36:09 . . . 11
Closings — 01:36:36–01:47:26 . . . 11
Combined Rankings and Assessment . . . 11
The strongest three offered distinct choices . . . 11
Changes, clarifications, and tensions between debates . . . 11
Where the debates agreed . . . 12
Fact Checks and Unresolved Claims . . . 12
1. The $4 million figure is a documented infrastructure funding gap . . . 12
2. Tax figures need definitions . . . 12
3. Gervais's strong-mayor statement requires qualification . . . 12
4. The land-purchase dispute does not establish wrongdoing . . . 13
5. The electric-bus grant dispute has more context than the debate provided . . . 13
6. The $28.7 million water grant is corroborated . . . 13
7. The modular-housing initiative is real, but future delivery is still a forecast . . . 13
8. The posted asset-management issue deserves a precise answer . . . 13
9. Crime, college housing, and demographic numbers remain unverified here . . . 13
10. Claims about people being transported into Pembroke remain allegations . . . 14
The Most Important Unanswered Questions . . . 14
Timestamp Guide . . . 14

Pembroke Mayoral Debates: Full Report and Rankings

Revised October 13, 2026.

Debate 1 — Tuesday, September 22, 2026
Debate 2 — Monday, October 5, 2026

Overall Judgment

Brian Abdallah performed best in Debate 1, best in Debate 2, and best across the two combined. Stephanie LeMay was the strongest challenger on planning, communication, and accountability. Ron Gervais was the strongest on existing municipal programs and institutional knowledge. Their second/third positions are close; the separation between that leading group and the other three candidates is clearer.

Rank	Debate 1 — September 22, 2026	Debate 2 — October 5, 2026	Combined
1	Brian Abdallah	Brian Abdallah	Brian Abdallah
2	Stephanie LeMay	Stephanie LeMay	Stephanie LeMay
3	Ron Gervais	Ron Gervais	Ron Gervais
4	Griffith James Slaughter	Griffith James Slaughter	Griffith James Slaughter
5	Stanley Everett Sambey	Stanley Everett Sambey	Stanley Everett Sambey
6	Bill Michaelis	Bill Michaelis	Bill Michaelis

The order remained the same after assessing the debates separately. That does not mean the performances were identical: LeMay made a stronger case for her experience in Debate 2; Gervais supplied a fuller record and more specific housing tools; Sambey gave more concrete information about his proposed governing style; and Slaughter developed his waterfront and accessibility ideas.

These are subjective rankings of the arguments and demonstrated preparation in these debates, not an election prediction or a finding about anyone's character. They are not a substitute for examining candidates' full platforms and records.

Sources and Method

The two supplied recordings are identified throughout this report as follows:

Recording	Event date	Length	Public recording
Debate 1	Tuesday, September 22, 2026	Approximately 1:28:35	Debate 1
Debate 2	Monday, October 5, 2026	Approximately 1:49:02	Debate 2

Debate 1 took place at Festival Hall and was moderated by Cindy Mills. Debate 2 was hosted by the Rotary Club at Pembroke Legion Branch 72 and moderated by Tim McCann. The dates above identify the events.

I reviewed the full English automatic-caption text for both exact matching recordings, in the requested order. I extracted the supplied recordings' audio and independently transcribed selected important passages: Gervais's land-purchase explanation, Sambey's transit subsidy figure, Abdallah's transit answer, the electric-bus grant exchange, and LeMay's discussion of her professional experience. I also inspected an on-screen candidate identification and checked selected claims against public sources.

This is primarily a content assessment. I did not continuously watch and listen to all three hours and eighteen minutes. Accordingly, I assess clarity of answers, argument structure, responsiveness, stated policies, and recorded turn-taking. I do not claim to have comprehensively assessed vocal tone, facial expressions, posture, or audience reactions. Automatic captions contain errors in names, place names, numbers, and speaker boundaries; uncertain details are identified rather than silently treated as proven.

The ranking gives most weight to:

1. Answering the actual question and naming useful actions.
2. Explaining costs, constraints, and how actions could be delivered.
3. Using evidence responsibly and distinguishing plans from accomplishments.
4. Showing judgment about trade-offs and the mayor's relationship with council.
5. Communicating clearly and responding constructively to disagreement.

I did not give points simply for saying more, using larger numbers, making sharper accusations, or promising more projects. I have avoided numerical scores because they would imply a precision this review does not support.

Candidate name spellings were checked against the City's certified candidate list.

Debate 1 — Tuesday, September 22, 2026

Rankings and Reasons

1. Brian Abdallah **Why first:** He offered the broadest collection of specific actions and connected several issues into a coherent strategy: housing and business growth to strengthen revenues, transit to help people access employment, partnerships to share costs, and neighborhood engagement to improve accountability. He gave residents more concrete material to assess than most competitors.

His strongest answers were transit, downtown businesses, housing coordination, and advisory committees. He proposed a housing summit and ten-year coordinated housing plan; shared business space and pop-up stores; stronger property standards; neighborhood budget meetings; and restoration of seniors' input. On recreation, he supported maintaining existing facilities while planning a future complex subject to affordability.

The transit answer at approximately **00:46:53** was particularly strong as an argument: he cited ridership and work trips, explained the service's social and economic value, and acknowledged that public services require subsidies. The numbers remain claims unless independently checked, but he supplied a rationale rather than merely an endorsement.

What held him back: He interrupted Gervais during the electric-bus grant exchange around **00:51:48–00:53:05**, and the moderator had to protect Gervais's opportunity to finish. His emphasis on accepting grants understated the need to assess the complete project cost. Claims about committee arrangements having no cost were too absolute. His broad growth strategy lacked a quantified timetable, operating budget, or housing delivery target.

Assessment: Best policy breadth and practical agenda, with a real weakness in debate restraint and incomplete costing.

2. Stephanie LeMay **Why second:** She was consistently focused on planning, affordability, readable information, and results. She offered a clear alternative to both the incumbent's defense of existing systems and more sweeping promises from other challengers.

Her strongest moment was the transparency answer at approximately **00:33:13–00:34:13**: publishing long reports is insufficient if residents cannot easily understand what was decided, why, how much it costs, and when it will happen. On safety, she proposed day and night audits and a public dashboard. On advisory committees, she supported reinstatement with clear mandates and outcomes. Her business answer identified CNL and the military base's supply chains as potential targets.

She also challenged the delay in recreation planning around **00:18:13**, asking why the work had not reached a stage where the city could act. That was a useful accountability question, although the ensuing explanation about a change in project scope deserved consideration.

What held her back: Her approach was stronger on decision-making processes than on firm commitments. She did not give an affordable recreation option, a savings target, or a specific housing production plan. At times the answer was to improve planning before choosing a direction.

Assessment: Strongest challenger on governance and clarity; slightly behind Abdallah on actionable policy breadth.

3. Ron Gervais **Why third:** He demonstrated the strongest familiarity with current municipal arrangements: capital cost-sharing limits, existing recreation work, county programs, the distinct purpose of Handi-Bus, and the Community Improvement Plan. His insistence on considering the taxpayer's share was a necessary contribution.

His recreation answer at approximately **00:13:52** described existing costs and why a large new complex would be difficult to finance. His homelessness answer identified actual collaborative programs, including MESA and transitional housing. His reply to the land-purchase criticism at **00:39:29** was much more specific than the allegations: he described the unopened road allowance, the appraisal, the price, and his conflict declaration.

What held him back: He often defended the existing approach more effectively than he set out a new one. On transparency, the fact that meetings are available online did not fully address LeMay's point about accessible explanations. His transit cost concerns were legitimate, but he did not clearly present a better service model.

Explaining why committees cost money also left unanswered how affected groups would have an effective voice after committees were removed.

Assessment: Strong institutional knowledge and fiscal caution, but a less compelling forward agenda. His position is close to LeMay's; an assessment weighted more heavily toward current municipal experience could place him second.

4. Griffith James Slaughter **Why fourth:** He offered a recognizable three-part platform: explore regional reunification, declare an emergency over the downtown social crisis, and attract business. He consistently supported cooperation and helping people experiencing homelessness or addiction, rather than speaking only about removing them.

His willingness to discuss shelter and rehabilitation needs was useful. His support for coordinated transit and more activity downtown also addressed real community concerns.

What held him back: He rarely explained the funding, legal mechanism, governing arrangement, or sequence needed to implement those ideas. He treated an emergency declaration as a route to help without naming the funding program or demonstrating that it would deliver resources. His proposed requirement to occupy vacant buildings within months was not supported by an explanation of municipal authority or market realities.

Assessment: Coherent priorities and constructive intent, with much less implementation detail than the leading three.

5. Stanley Everett Sambey **Why fifth:** He clearly articulated dissatisfaction with the city's direction and repeatedly asked whether taxpayers were getting value. He was willing to question subsidy levels, infrastructure capacity, and accountability. Brevity sometimes made his central point easier to identify.

What held him back: His repeated emphasis on self-sufficiency did not become a revenue or service plan. He offered criticisms of homelessness management with little detail about treatment or housing. He initially described a $4 million operating deficit, later referring to an infrastructure deficit. Those are materially different concepts. His claim that the CAO and clerk were merged was directly disputed by Gervais. His college-housing example and crime figures lacked adequate sourcing and definitions.

Assessment: Clear protest and accountability message, but insufficiently reliable supporting claims and insufficient practical alternatives.

6. Bill Michaelis **Why sixth:** He brought firsthand observations about buildings, accessibility, lighting, transit signs, maintenance, and the waterfront. Repairing existing assets and improving access are useful priorities. His concern for food insecurity and young people also emerged repeatedly.

What held him back: His answers frequently moved away from the question into anecdotes or unrelated projects. He made serious allegations and claims about people being brought into the city without establishing them. Proposals to control who comes into Pembroke or send people away were not accompanied by a demonstrated lawful municipal process. A pledge to donate 70% of his mayoral wage did not establish how much money would be available or which recurring costs it could cover.

Assessment: Numerous practical observations, but the weakest organized and substantiated case for governing the city.

Debate 1 — Complete Topic Summary

Tuesday, September 22, 2026.

The introduction describes one-minute openings, one-minute answers from each candidate, four-minute open discussions, and one-minute closings. Although eleven questions are mentioned, **seven substantive questions were reached**, with no open discussion after the last one.

Opening statements — approximately 00:04:05–00:08:35

Abdallah framed his candidacy around accessibility, service, safety, affordability, transit, and housing partnerships. Slaughter introduced his three pillars. Gervais emphasized experience, relationships, difficult decisions, and protecting taxpayers. LeMay emphasized clear priorities and accountability. Michaelis emphasized his family's building

background, maintenance, lighting, and unity. Sambey posed the election as a choice about the city's direction and kept his opening short.

1. Recreation and fiscal responsibility — 00:08:44–00:20:35

Question: Should the city build a new multipurpose complex or repair existing facilities, and how would it pay?

Candidate	Position and proposed approach
Abdallah	Maintain existing facilities; plan a future regional complex; seek growth, development-related revenues, grants, and partners.
LeMay	Establish affordability and resident priorities before choosing; distinguish needs from wants; challenge delays in committee work.
Gervais	A large complex is unaffordable at present; explain current repair spending and inadequate neighboring capital contributions.
Slaughter	Supports the idea of a new center but would maintain current assets and look for outside investment.
Sambey	Likes the concept but says finances must be put in order and questions past maintenance.
Michaelis	Firmly opposes a new structure; favors repairs, more use of existing ice, and advertising revenue.

Key exchange: LeMay challenged the time spent without a ready project. Abdallah described deferral to the next council. Gervais explained that the proposal had become an additional indoor turf facility rather than a replacement for the pool and arenas.

My reading: The real disagreement was over affordability, scope, and sequencing. Nearly everyone accepted the need for recreation and the need to maintain current assets. No one presented a fully costed replacement option.

2. Homelessness, mental health, and addiction — 00:20:43–00:32:17

Question: What should the city do to combine compassion, support, and public safety?

Candidate	Position and proposed approach
Gervais	Regional collaboration, drug strategy work, MESA, and transitional housing; enforcement alone will not resolve the problem.
Abdallah	Continue partnerships, advocate for funding appropriate to a hub community, support prevention and community watch, and increase focused patrols.
LeMay	Day/night safety audits, public reporting, partner coordination, and explicit mayoral accountability for public well-being.
Slaughter	Emergency declaration, a larger shelter response, rehabilitation, and support workers.
Sambey	Emphasizes enforcement and accountability; cites longer-term crime increases and demands faster results.
Michaelis	Describes helping people directly but also claims outsiders are being brought in and proposes stopping that.

Important nuance: Gervais's claim of recent quarterly improvement and Sambey's claim of deterioration since 2012 are not necessarily contradictory. Different periods and different measures can move differently. Neither supplied the full comparable series in the debate.

My reading: Gervais gave the fullest description of existing programs; LeMay offered the clearest public accountability mechanism. Slaughter identified unmet needs but not an implementation plan. The debate did not establish shelter capacity, treatment demand, costs, or an enforceable delivery schedule.

3. Public trust and transparency — 00:32:19–00:42:17

Question: How should a mayor address a reasonably perceived conflict even when no legal wrongdoing has been found?

LeMay proposed accessible explanations of decisions, costs, schedules, and reasons. Abdallah proposed public statements and recusal, neighborhood meetings, and reopening the legal-services arrangement to competition; he also criticized the absence of an executive meeting arrangement he expected. Gervais emphasized livestreaming, lawful confidentiality, conflict declarations, and the advice/reporting surrounding the land purchase. Slaughter advocated avoiding transactions that create conflicts. Sambey said even perceived impropriety should prompt resignation and criticized the distribution of administrative authority. Michaelis attacked the land transaction without establishing his allegations.

My reading: LeMay answered the broader public-trust question best. Gervais made the strongest specific factual rebuttal. Legal compliance and accessible public explanations are separate standards; meeting one does not automatically satisfy the other.

4. Public transit and Handi-Bus — 00:42:21–00:53:15

Question: Should transit continue or expand, and how should the general and specialized services work together?

Abdallah supported the service and cited use for work, ridership above the expected range, possible local dispatch, and coordination between services. LeMay supported transit while calling for reliability, easier booking, and clear pilot measures. Gervais explained that door-to-door service for people with significant needs is different from stop-to-stop service and questioned the taxpayer share and fare level. Slaughter proposed closer coordination and more regular service. Sambey asked whether the per-trip subsidy was acceptable. Michaelis supported transit and drew attention to missing signs and booking problems, while introducing unsupported general claims about nonprofit finances.

Key exchange: Abdallah criticized the rejection of an approximately $500,000 electric-bus grant and claimed savings of $321,000. Gervais defended caution over charging infrastructure and the full public cost. Their exchange became the debate's most contentious section.

My reading: Abdallah made the best case for the service's value. Gervais raised the right question about total cost. The debate did not supply the complete financial comparison needed to decide the electric-bus dispute.

5. Diversity, inclusion, and advisory committees — 00:53:20–01:02:20

Gervais defended merging/removing committees to reduce staff demands and described relationships with Indigenous, multicultural, and LGBTQ community organizations. Abdallah supported restoring seniors' and diversity input, with volunteer administration where possible. LeMay supported committees with clear mandates, outputs, and accountability. Slaughter supported inclusive representation and restoring the diversity committee. Sambey favored treating residents through broad age categories rather than identity-specific groups. Michaelis opposed excessive committees and emphasized unity, direct action, and his salary-donation pledge.

My reading: LeMay best combined participation with an explanation of purpose and cost discipline. Abdallah gave the clearest reinstatement commitment. Gervais explained the past decision but offered less detail about replacement mechanisms.

6. Business, downtown vacancies, and housing — 01:02:26–01:13:27

Abdallah proposed a housing summit, coordinated plan, the modular-housing partnership, pop-ups, shared business spaces, window improvements, property standards, and collaboration with downtown owners. LeMay proposed putting underused property to work, attracting CNL/base supply-chain businesses, strengthening partnerships, and supporting skilled grant preparation. Gervais explained the Community Improvement Plan, active development proposals, possible provincial permission for a commercial vacancy tax, and tourism reinvestment through accommodation-tax revenue. Slaughter proposed stronger action on empty buildings and selling the city to investors.

Sambey emphasized capacity constraints and student demand for rentals. Michaelis proposed events, food production, agricultural businesses, better windows, and free parking.

My reading: Abdallah supplied the fullest municipal action list. LeMay supplied a credible target for investment attraction. Gervais supplied the most detail about existing mechanisms. None demonstrated how many additional homes would be delivered by a particular date.

7. Shared services and possible amalgamation — 01:13:39–01:19:58

Abdallah supported more sharing, renegotiated recreation contributions, discussion of a regional fire model, and studying amalgamation with public input. LeMay strongly supported partnerships but thought amalgamation premature until Pembroke understood its own position. Gervais described current collaboration on water, energy, recreation, health, and highway advocacy. Slaughter wanted to explore reunification and wider shared services. Sambey rejected dependence on other municipalities in favor of self-sufficiency. Michaelis favored repairing existing assets and making partnerships work.

My reading: Shared service agreements and municipal amalgamation are different choices. Slaughter blurred them most. No merger study, net-savings estimate, or agreed regional proposal was presented.

Closing statements — 01:20:26–01:24:53

Abdallah restated practical first actions and opposed strong mayor powers. LeMay emphasized visible improvement and encouraged voting. Gervais emphasized experience and fiscal responsibility while criticizing rivals' experience or spending judgments. Slaughter emphasized attracting business and more services. Sambey directed voters to his policy papers. Michaelis emphasized building, purpose, and controlling the city's social problems.

Debate 2 — Monday, October 5, 2026

Rankings and Reasons

1. Brian Abdallah He again supplied the broadest actionable program. The longer format helped him connect budget review, regional cost-sharing, housing, downtown activity, and community participation. His downtown answer at **01:19:58–01:20:54** offered a concrete menu: lighting/camera assessment, incubators, pop-ups, housing downtown, and stronger property standards. His housing answer identified stalled subdivisions and the need to identify development barriers.

He also answered LeMay's challenge to the summit's cost at **01:07:04–01:08:31**, saying sponsors and partners would support it and that he would pay the hall rental. This addressed direct expenditure more than staff time, but it showed a response to criticism.

His blanket grant-acceptance language remained a weakness, and several answers returned to the summit without setting unit targets or deadlines. Still, he did the most to turn a general ambition into a set of potential municipal actions.

2. Stephanie LeMay Debate 2 strengthened her case substantially. Her opening at **00:15:25** explained experience in complex projects, contracts, teams, and governance. Her closing at **01:39:08–01:40:57** identified her AECL contract-management role, retirement plans, and involvement in a major long-term contract. These are statements she made, not a complete independent verification of her career.

She proposed a budget starting from already committed costs, prioritization based on risk, clearer public reports, protection of waterfront green space, and long-term waterfront leases rather than land sales. She distinguished enforcing existing property standards from immediately rewriting them.

Her weakest answer was the measurable-results question at 01:33:40–01:34:16. After repeatedly emphasizing measurable outcomes, she mainly asked residents whether they felt informed and satisfied. Those are valid measures of experience, but she did not provide the numerical targets or baselines the question invited. Her criticism of subdivision contracts also assumed the nature of the city's leverage without showing the actual agreements.

She remains second because her overall approach was coherent, responsive, and forward-looking. Gervais was stronger on existing tools and tangible development measures; their placement remains a close judgment.

3. Ron Gervais He improved on Debate 1 by presenting a fuller record: infrastructure investment, water funding, industrial development, and specific housing grants. His housing answer at **01:02:02–01:03:06** identified additional-unit, affordable-housing, downtown-housing, and multi-unit grants. That was one of the most concrete answers to what a municipality can do now.

He also gave a better answer than LeMay to the measurable-results question: actual construction, industrial jobs, and subdivisions coming to fruition. His response to the emergency-declaration proposal identified a genuine problem: a declaration does not itself demonstrate a funding entitlement.

However, he remained strongly defensive of current arrangements, and his categorical claim at **00:44:36–00:45:39** that he had not used strong mayor powers needs qualification. A published 2025 decision invokes those powers for committees. That is not proof of overriding council, but it weakens an unqualified statement of non-use. See the fact-check section.

4. Griffith James Slaughter He developed his strongest subject, the waterfront, using his experience taking people onto the river. He added accessibility and seniors' independence to his housing answer and suggested connecting young entrepreneurs with Algonquin College. His consistent emphasis on treatment, tourism, business, and regional cooperation helped keep his platform identifiable.

He still did not establish the funding mechanism for rehabilitation, a workable reunification structure, or how an emergency declaration would obtain support. His infrastructure answer described finding the worst problems and reviewing the budget, but did not provide a decision rule as specific as the leading candidates' asset-management discussion.

5. Stanley Everett Sambey He supplied more concrete proposals here than in Debate 1: a department-by-department forensic audit, a spending moratorium, a referendum on major priorities, and deliberate use of strong mayor powers with written explanations. Voters received a much clearer picture of his intended governing style.

His acknowledgment that some positions are excluded from strong mayor personnel powers was a useful distinction. His willingness to exercise executive powers was also candid, though it does not by itself demonstrate good judgment about when to use them.

He continued to rely on unverified housing and crime figures and repeated the belief that investment would follow once the city's house was in order. The moratorium lacked exceptions for necessary services, mandatory work, and urgent failures. He did not show how his audit would deliver the proposed savings. This added detail was not enough to move him ahead of Slaughter overall.

6. Bill Michaelis His maintenance background, concern about infrastructure, and proposals for waterfront events were clearer with more time. He raised electricity capacity, public access, free parking, reuse, and food production.

However, his answer to transparency moved quickly into maintenance and social issues; his affordability answer moved into reopening a jail and solar generation; and his measurable-results answer returned to enthusiasm and a salary pledge. These illustrate persistent difficulty answering the specific question with a testable plan. Unsupported claims about outsiders and municipal control over people's movements continued to weaken the case.

Debate 2 — Complete Topic Summary

Monday, October 5, 2026.

Debate 2's format allowed three-minute openings, directed questions to individual candidates, replies from the other candidates, general questions, and three-minute closing opportunities. It yielded six directed questions and four general questions. The longer answers made it more useful for understanding governing approaches, though there was less direct confrontation than in Debate 1.

Opening statements — 00:07:21–00:21:33

Abdallah described his record, cost pressures, low budget-meeting participation, housing plans, and neighborhood meetings. Michaelis described his trades background and a repair-first agenda. Slaughter described regional reunification, an emergency declaration, recovery, and business/tourism. LeMay introduced her professional experience and disciplined planning. Gervais gave a detailed record and emphasized fiscal responsibility. Sambey described previous political and business involvement and asked voters to choose change.

1. Three priorities — directed to LeMay, 00:21:58–00:29:39

LeMay selected taxes/budget discipline, recreation decisions, and safety, though she left little time for the third item. Abdallah selected tax stabilization through review and growth, safety, and water-rate pressures. Gervais grouped his priorities around the economy/finances, infrastructure, and social safety. Slaughter emphasized downtown businesses, housing, and recreation if affordable. Sambey proposed an audit and spending restraint before expansion. Michaelis emphasized safety and taxes but did not supply a clearly structured three-item program.

My reading: Broad agreement masked a major unanswered question: what would each candidate stop or postpone to fund the chosen priorities?

2. Meaningful transparency — directed to Michaelis, 00:29:46–00:37:03

Michaelis questioned legislative readings but shifted into maintenance and safety. LeMay proposed plain-language reporting and challenged whether the current asset-management material was posted. Abdallah proposed neighborhood meetings, retirement-home visits, videos, and easier reporting of concerns. Slaughter supported clear, widely available information. Sambey favored much broader access to bylaws and internal rules. Gervais explained livestreaming and the separation of committee consideration from final council adoption.

My reading: LeMay and Abdallah were stronger on reaching residents; Gervais was stronger on explaining existing procedures. Wider access still needs legitimate privacy and confidentiality boundaries.

3. Waterfront revitalization — directed to Sambey, 00:37:27–00:43:53

Sambey proposed waterfront businesses and a revived water culture. Slaughter emphasized tourism, boating, history, and marina opportunity. LeMay proposed green-space protection and long leases rather than land sales. Abdallah described a restaurant/pub and retail concept, preservation of the arboretum and event space, and more input from younger residents. Michaelis proposed tournaments, regattas, inflatable recreation, and additional dock rentals. Gervais described the arboretum, trail connections, procurement, and planned public engagement.

My reading: This was the strongest area of consensus. LeMay stated the clearest ownership boundary. Slaughter had the strongest connection to the activity itself. Costs, public access, seasonal operations, and procurement remained underdeveloped.

4. Strong mayor powers — directed to Gervais, 00:44:02–00:50:05

Candidate	Stated approach
Abdallah	Opposes them and promises not to use them; says his exemption motion was a request rather than an insult to the province.
Gervais	Says he has not used them and favors working with council; his public statement retains discretion.
LeMay	Sees little ordinary need, but leaves a possible exception for exceptional emergencies with provincial direction.
Slaughter	Does not foresee a need; decisions should be made with the community and council.
Sambey	Would use them deliberately to implement change, while publishing explanations and recognizing protected positions.
Michaelis	Supports some stronger authority, coupled with consultation and a protective leadership role.

My reading: This was the clearest disagreement about how power would be exercised. Emergency response and strong mayor legislation should not be treated as interchangeable legal authorities. A promise not to exercise discretionary powers also does not remove duties imposed by statute.

5. Infrastructure versus visible projects — directed to Slaughter, 00:50:14–00:57:20

Slaughter prioritized budget review, roads and service problems, and coordination of construction. Michaelis proposed resurfacing and shopping for better contractors, beginning downtown. Gervais described systematic asset decisions, traffic considerations, underground services, and investment already underway. Abdallah described the pavement-condition index, staff recommendations, water planning, and regulatory obligations. LeMay tied risk-based decisions to understandable public construction schedules. Sambey proposed a public choice over roads and recreation alongside belt-tightening.

My reading: Gervais and Abdallah gave the strongest technical explanation. LeMay explained how to make that reasoning visible to residents. Public input helps set service levels, but basic infrastructure decisions cannot rest solely on which project is more popular.

6. Affordable housing — directed to Abdallah, 00:57:31–01:03:50

Abdallah proposed a summit, a coordinated plan, removing barriers in stagnant subdivisions, and modular housing partnerships. LeMay questioned the contracts behind dormant development and the cost/value of a summit. Slaughter emphasized accessibility, including seniors' independent living. Sambey returned to student rental demand and long-term-care pressures, while clarifying that he was not advocating college closure. Gervais identified subdivision deregistration as a provincial tool and listed existing housing grants. Michaelis emphasized electricity capacity needed for new development.

My reading: Gervais best answered which concrete municipal tools already exist. Abdallah best described coordination across actors. LeMay offered useful scrutiny but fewer direct housing-supply actions. Rental housing, home ownership, accessible housing, and long-term care are different needs and require distinct solutions.

7. Services, infrastructure, and property taxes — 01:04:33–01:10:29

Sambey favored putting finances in order first. Slaughter favored regional sharing/reunification. LeMay favored disciplined spending, measurable results, and tax-base growth. Abdallah favored budget and agreement reviews, provincial funding reform, and growth; he also replied to the summit-cost challenge. Michaelis proposed jail and energy initiatives. Gervais emphasized needs versus wants, cost-sharing limitations, and transit's tax implications.

My reading: No candidate produced a fully costed tax strategy. Stabilizing taxes was an aspiration shared by several candidates, not a demonstrated outcome. New assessment, development charges, user fees, and grants are different revenues with different uses and risks.

8. Barriers to economic growth — 01:10:36–01:18:12

Gervais emphasized the business environment, serviced industrial land, electricity, and high taxes. Michaelis emphasized street conditions, perceived safety, and energy production. Abdallah described business-retention work, investment strategy, transit, events, the corporate park, health-related business, and CNL/base opportunities. LeMay emphasized targeting actual supply-chain needs. Slaughter emphasized safety, rehabilitation, tourism, and selling the city. Sambey emphasized security, capacity, and municipal finances.

My reading: LeMay was most precise about identifying likely customers for incoming businesses. Abdallah had the most comprehensive place-and-investment strategy. Gervais explained available assets. None showed an investor pipeline, customer commitment, or independently quantified jobs forecast.

9. Downtown vacancies and safety — 01:18:25–01:28:46

Abdallah proposed safety assessments, business incubators, pop-ups, downtown housing, and improved property standards. LeMay proposed direct consultation and enforcing existing standards before rewriting them. Slaughter proposed emergency action, recovery support, and opportunities for student entrepreneurs. Sambey proposed biomass and digital industries but stressed capacity first. Gervais described security grants, local shopping, a vacancy-tax request, and possible forthcoming property improvements; he challenged the emergency declaration's funding assumptions. Michaelis proposed free parking, advertising in windows, and expanded food/agricultural activity.

My reading: Abdallah offered the strongest list of immediate experiments. LeMay offered the clearest enforcement distinction. Gervais made an important objection to treating declarations as funding guarantees. Industrial/data-center proposals might affect the wider economy but were not clearly tied to filling ordinary downtown storefronts.

10. Measurable results after four years — 01:29:00–01:36:09

Abdallah named safer public places, occupancy downtown, affordable homes, subdivision activity, taxes, recreation maintenance, events, and participation. Gervais named construction, industrial jobs, and completed subdivision development. Slaughter named a busy downtown, waterfront, employment, youth activity, and recovery provision. LeMay stressed whether residents understood decisions and saw results they wanted. Sambey wanted a visible change in direction and no need for a second term. Michaelis stressed safety, maintenance, free parking, and his salary donation.

My reading: Gervais gave the most directly observable development measures. Abdallah gave the widest set of outcomes. Almost everyone omitted numerical baselines and targets. LeMay missed a chance to demonstrate the measurement discipline she advocated throughout both debates.

Closings — 01:36:36–01:47:26

Sambey urged a break with past practice. Gervais emphasized experience and relationships in a changing council. LeMay made the strongest statement of her professional credentials and full-time commitment. Slaughter returned to his pillars and regional tourism/business opportunity. Michaelis emphasized reuse, trades, costs, and wage donation. Abdallah gave the most detailed recap of his intended actions and restated his opposition to strong mayor powers.

Combined Rankings and Assessment

The strongest three offered distinct choices

Abdallah offered the clearest practical agenda. His main strategy was to connect development, public services, affordability, and resident engagement. His weakness was that coordinating people and finding grants is not the same as producing housing or demonstrating net savings. His policy detail earned first place, but it should be followed by budgets and targets.

LeMay offered the clearest case for improving how the city makes decisions. Her strongest contribution was turning transparency into usable information and turning affordability into disciplined prioritization. Her weakness was the gap between promising measurement and actually naming measurable commitments.

Gervais offered the clearest explanation of the city's current operations and constraints. He frequently grounded debate in programs, agreements, and investment already underway. His weakness was a tendency to treat those explanations as sufficient answers to dissatisfaction. The formal strong-mayor decision also requires a more careful account of what he meant by non-use.

Changes, clarifications, and tensions between debates

Candidate	What became clearer	What remained unresolved
Abdallah	More detail on summit funding, downtown actions, youth engagement, and the intended governing agenda.	Summit delivery targets, complete costing, and overly unconditional grant language.
LeMay	Professional experience, full-time intention, waterfront leasing preference, and risk-based budget approach.	Firm outcomes, a specific housing program, and the legal leverage assumed over stagnant subdivisions.
Gervais	Fuller infrastructure record, specific housing grants, and tangible development measures.	Non-use wording for strong mayor powers and how existing methods would change to address public concerns.
Slaughter	Waterfront experience, accessibility, student-business links, and more explicit recovery proposals.	Emergency-funding mechanism, regional governance arrangements, and reliable savings estimates.
Sambey	Audit, restraint, referendum, and executive-power proposals; explicit clarification against college closure.	Data quality, audit savings, essential-service exceptions, and a workable social-support response.

Candidate	What became clearer	What remained unresolved
Michaelis	More detail on reuse, electricity capacity, events, and proposed wage-funded projects.	Question responsiveness, substantiation, municipal authority, and a complete budget.

Most candidates were broadly consistent. Additional detail is not automatically a contradiction. There were, however, notable shifts or qualifications:

- Sambey's terminology became an infrastructure shortfall rather than the operating-deficit language used early in Debate 1. His student-housing estimate also varied from roughly 600–700 to 700–900 units across the discussions. Neither estimate was established.
- Sambey's second debate made willingness to use strong mayor powers unequivocal; this is a clarification of his agenda rather than proof that he reversed a prior promise.
- LeMay's more explicit recreation prioritization in Debate 2 did not amount to an unconditional commitment to a new complex. She retained an affordability and assessment condition.
- Michaelis said he had considered freezing taxes but expressed uncertainty in Debate 2. That is less definite than a guaranteed freeze.
- Abdallah's second debate addressed direct summit funding, but did not demonstrate that municipal staff involvement would be costless.
- Gervais's claim of no use of strong mayor powers needs to be narrowed to whatever specific kind of use he intended; the documentary distinction matters.

Where the debates agreed

The candidates broadly recognized aging infrastructure, affordability pressures, downtown vacancies, safety concerns, and underused waterfront potential. Several supported economic growth and regional cooperation. The disagreements were mainly about priorities, authority, costs, the usefulness of committees, and whether current progress was sufficient.

The repeated issue behind nearly every topic was **capacity**: Pembroke wants more activity and better services while struggling to maintain what it already has. Growth can help, but it also creates costs. Repairing assets matters, but doing nothing to generate new activity has costs too. A credible mayoral program needs both a service plan and a revenue plan.

Fact Checks and Unresolved Claims

1. The $4 million figure is a documented infrastructure funding gap

The City's budget announcement describes approximately $11 million in annual infrastructure use/requirements with sustainable funding of about $7 million. The resulting $4 million gap supports concern about underfunding assets, but does not establish an annual operating-budget deficit. Sambey's initial wording was misleadingly broad; Gervais's response that budgets cannot simply run deficits did not dispose of the underlying asset-funding problem. City budget announcement.

2. Tax figures need definitions

The same December 2025 announcement states a proposed 6.99% levy increase after assessment growth, including 2.36% for county/shared services and 4.63% for the city portion. Abdallah's debate figure combines county and OPP pressures differently. Those figures should not be compared without checking final budget classifications. A levy increase, tax-rate change, and an individual household's bill change are not automatically identical. City budget announcement.

3. Gervais's strong-mayor statement requires qualification

At approximately 00:44:36 in Debate 2, Gervais repeatedly says he has not used the powers. **Mayoral Decision MD-001-2025**, dated June 25, 2025, expressly invokes the Municipal Act's special mayoral authority to establish committees and confirm appointments. It retains existing arrangements and provides for consideration of council

input. That is evidence of formal use, not evidence of a hostile override of council. The fair conclusion is that an absolute claim of never using any of these powers is too broad. Published decision.

His June 19, 2025 statement retains discretion to use the powers thoughtfully and in the community's interest, while emphasizing cooperation. It does not contain Abdallah's categorical promise never to use discretionary powers. Gervais's public statement.

Ontario's framework includes distinct budget, committee, staffing, and provincial-priority functions, with limits and protected positions. It should not be summarized as unlimited firing authority or a general emergency power. Ontario's official guide.

4. The land-purchase dispute does not establish wrongdoing

The moderator explicitly framed the question around concerns where no wrongdoing had been found. Local reporting supports the $790 appraisal, $1,000 purchase price, and conflict-declaration explanation. The reporting on commissioner advice does not support Michaelis's corruption implications. Lawful conduct can still raise questions about public confidence, but those are different claims. Sale reporting and commissioner-advice reporting.

The City's integrity-commissioner page lists documents concerning different dates and issues. One should not treat every listed report as addressing this same land transaction.

5. The electric-bus grant dispute has more context than the debate provided

Contemporaneous reporting identifies grant support for electric buses and charging infrastructure, initial cost problems, and a revised proposal. It supports the existence of the dispute. It does not by itself independently audit the claimed net savings or establish that rejecting the proposal was financially right or wrong. The full capital, operating, maintenance, charging, and contract comparison is needed. September 2025 reporting, page A5.

The argument that public grants ultimately use public money is true in a general sense but does not answer which option costs Pembroke taxpayers less. Conversely, the existence of a grant does not automatically make a project worthwhile. This is a weakness in both sides' framing.

6. The $28.7 million water grant is corroborated

The City confirms provincial funding of $28.7 million for a project estimated at $39.4 million, covering 73% of costs, with the balance shared under the water-services arrangement. This supports Gervais's claim about a major grant while also illustrating why grant size alone is an incomplete affordability measure. City announcement.

7. The modular-housing initiative is real, but future delivery is still a forecast

The housing partner describes discussions about locating a factory in Pembroke, and local reporting describes the land and facility proposal with production targeted for 2027. This corroborates an initiative, not completed factory operations or a guaranteed housing output. Credit also belongs to staff, council, developers, partners, and funders. Housing partner and facility reporting.

8. The posted asset-management issue deserves a precise answer

The City's reports page lists a July 2024 non-core asset plan, supporting LeMay's observation about the material residents could find. That does not alone prove that a newer consolidated plan does not exist or that the City is legally noncompliant. The proper follow-up is to request the current approved consolidated plan, approval date, and publication location. City reports page.

9. Crime, college housing, and demographic numbers remain unverified here

Sambey's figures need the underlying dataset, geographic coverage, years, denominators, and distinction between incidents, crime rates, and crime-severity indices. A long-term association after a policing change does not establish that the change caused the increase. Recent quarterly improvements and long-term increases can coexist.

His student-housing claim needs clarification of beds versus dwellings, student-only versus mixed rentals, and what would realistically become available. Closing a college would also affect jobs, income, and demand; he clarified that he was not proposing closure.

Claims about large numbers of seniors waiting for care need a verified, deduplicated list and a distinction between retirement housing, long-term care, and ordinary accessible rentals. Abdallah's claim about the share of residents over 60 was not independently confirmed here.

10. Claims about people being transported into Pembroke remain allegations

The debates do not establish an organized multi-province scheme bringing people to Pembroke. Personal observations and assertions do not establish its scale, origin, responsibility, or legality. They should not be presented as verified facts or used to infer wrongdoing by identified individuals.

The Most Important Unanswered Questions

Candidate	Most useful follow-up
Abdallah	How many homes and occupied storefronts by each year, at what total municipal cost? Provide the full electric-bus comparison and summit staff-time estimate.
LeMay	What are the first three measurable targets, what savings can be delivered, and which specific subdivision agreements provide the leverage she describes?
Gervais	Which practices will change next term? Clarify his strong-mayor statement and publish the complete transit cost comparison and regional contribution proposals.
Slaughter	What exact program would fund the emergency response and recovery facility, and what is the governance/cost study behind reunification?
Sambey	Publish the crime and housing sources, audit cost and projected savings, moratorium exceptions, and criteria for exercising executive authority.
Michaelis	Present a prioritized costed program; substantiate transport claims; identify the municipal powers supporting proposals to relocate people.

Across the field, the missing common document is a simple four-year delivery table: action, responsible party, council approval needed, funding source, yearly target, and public reporting date. No candidate supplied that complete package in these debates.

Timestamp Guide

Times are approximate and refer to the recordings from their start. Public-video links open near the relevant section.

Debate 1 section	Time	Link
Opening statements	00:04:05	Open
Recreation	00:08:44	Open
Homelessness/addictions	00:20:43	Open
Trust/transparency	00:32:19	Open
Transit	00:42:21	Open
Grant confrontation	00:51:48	Open
Inclusion/committees	00:53:20	Open
Business/housing	01:02:26	Open
Regional services	01:13:39	Open
Closing statements	01:20:26	Open

Debate 2 section	Time	Link
Opening statements	00:07:21	Open
Three priorities	00:21:58	Open
Transparency	00:29:46	Open
Waterfront	00:37:27	Open
Strong mayor powers	00:44:02	Open
Infrastructure priorities	00:50:14	Open
Housing	00:57:31	Open
Services and taxes	01:04:33	Open
Economic growth	01:10:36	Open
Downtown	01:18:25	Open
Measurable results	01:29:00	Open
Closing statements	01:36:36	Open
LeMay's experience	01:39:08	Open

The accompanying full automatic-caption transcripts are provided as reference material. They contain recognition errors and do not reliably label speakers; use the recording to verify any quotation or uncertain number.